

SIPRA DAS



HOW ONE WISHES his freedom from the basic ills of Indian polity was combined with a contemporary, pragmatic approach.

ABHISHEK SINGHVI, CONGRESS SPOKESMAN

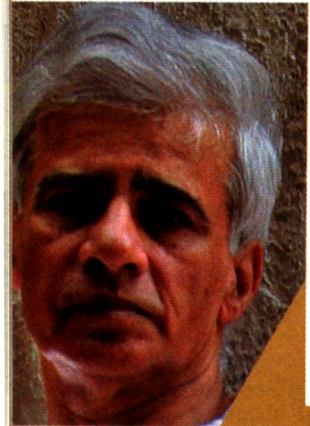
HEMANT CHAWLA



HE USED TO BE consistent, but ever since he supported the UPA, he is willing to proclaim but unwilling to strike.

ARUN JAITLEY, BJP GENERAL SECRETARY

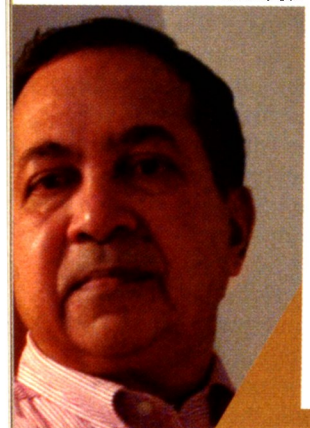
SARANG SEN



AT A PERSONAL LEVEL he is very charming, affectionate and friendly. But he is not an open, gregarious person.

VIVAN SUNDARAM, ARTIST

HK RAJASHEKAR



HE IS A PRINCIPLED general secretary. He does not court publicity. He reads and writes a lot and keeps to himself.

N. RAM, EDITOR, THE HINDU

any convincing explanation why India should jump on to the Bush bandwagon of democracy and fight against terrorism, given the awful record of the US in Iraq and its unilateral and aggressive efforts to destabilise popular governments around the world," Karat wrote in a party publication.

After two years of negotiations, Manmohan wanted the nuclear agreement, binding for 40 years, to be implemented and thought he had called the Left's bluff when he dared it to withdraw support to the Government. At the peak of the Left-Congress public debate on the nuclear agreement, Manmohan had said that history would not forgive his Government if the deal was not sealed. Karat's retort was: "History will not forgive us if we tie India's destiny to that of the United States in perpetuity." What underlines his opposition to the deal is not nuclear energy or national sovereignty or an independent foreign policy. It is driven by a pathological sense of anti-Americanism. After all, when were the Marxists champions of nuclear freedom?

Anti-imperialism rhymes with anti-capitalism. His fight against the "neo-liberal offensive of the bourgeoisie" is a permanent struggle in the market where Marx is pitted against Adam Smith. Marxists may not be enamoured of the stock market, but the feeling is mutual. On the day the Left Front announced its support to the UPA Government, the Sensex lost 800 points in two sessions. But while it later zoomed to over 20,000, little else in the policy domain survived the Left Front.

CPI(M), which lives in a time warp, continues to believe that the State knows best. Neither empirical evidence nor experience to the contrary matters. And thanks to their 60-plus strength in the Lok Sabha, the comrades have effectively played spoilsport in critical reforms, the worst hit being the financial sector. India's lumbering bureaucracy costs a packet in terms of salary, but it will cost much more in pension. Moving to a new pension system is imperative both for the Government and the employees, who will earn barely 8 per cent this year even as the Sensex has risen over 43 per cent. The ones to be denied the dividends of growth are the very sections that the Left professes to protect.

Take banking sector reforms, which Manmohan promised as early as September 2004, but hasn't been able to de-

SHANKAR



TONGUE TWIST: Karat addresses Keralites in English